

The Kitchen CABINET

Manmohan Singh's favourite five in the Cabinet provide a political shield to the least political prime minister

| By Priya Sahgal |

In the Manmohan Singh era, perhaps for the first time, politics has been taken out of the Prime Minister's Office (PMO). After installing an apolitical prime minister, Sonia Gandhi and her advisers took over the backroom politics of running a coalition. Manmohan's job is restricted to governance and 'the vision thing'. But he still needs political trouble-shooters who are part of the Government. A team that has both the clout and the credibility to help him implement the UPA's agenda; and also for the more mundane task of helping him run the Government. With Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee at the helm, this Government has a band of Union ministers who tend to manage much more than their own portfolios—whether it is placating unruly allies or liaising between the party and the Government. In fact, the damage control does not take place at 7 Race Course Road but at another Lutyen's Bungalow in Talkatora Road; or else across the road from South Block. Most of these ministers also have a working rapport with 10 Janpath (which adds to their credibility), but each is professional enough to give the prime minister his due. Unfortunately for Manmohan, there are many in the party who still regard him as an usurper despite his phenomenal comeback in the last elections. After all, he is not a Nehru-Gandhi who implicitly commands party loyalty. Neither is he an Atal Bihari Vajpayee who can carry the contradictions of a coalition along with the force of his own personality. Manmohan realises that his best governance accessory is his favourite band of ministers. Especially, as the party is quick to distance itself from the Government on tricky issues such as price rise, Indo-Pak talks and Telangana. During the Sharm el-Sheikh fiasco for instance, the Congress had lined a lightweight team of speakers to defend the prime minister in Parliament. It was then that Manmohan requested Mukherjee to speak and lend gravitas to his defence.

The task before these ministers is simple: to hardsell a UPA led by Manmohan Singh.



PRANAB MUKHERJEE

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